to work with other ‘philanthropic institutions like the Gates Foundation and some of the UN agencies’ to bring about the necessary changes.

A year later, Ratan and Bill Gates shared their growing angst in an opinion piece they co-authored on the problem of malnutrition that was adversely affecting 44 million children in the country resulting in their stunted growth. They concluded that proper nutrition was essential for ‘unlocking every child’s potential’. Nearly one-third of Indians are believed to be malnourished, with over 40 per cent of children not receiving adequate nutrition.

Underscoring the extreme importance of tackling this problem, they said: ‘These 44 million children are not just a statistic in a report. They are India’s future, and every single one of them deserves a chance to live a healthy life and productive life.’ In the same opinion piece, they conveyed their determination to make a difference. They wrote: ‘We believe the Indian people share our commitment to this, and we are optimistic that by working together, it is well within reach for India to tackle this very solvable challenge.’

For Ratan, philanthropy has no political boundaries either. It is a universal concern. He is convinced that Tata Trusts ‘should be willing to play’ its part in ‘trying to make a difference to the quality of life, wherever possible’. Similarly, he believes that with respect to his overall philosophy of maximum good for the maximum people, the goals of the Trusts should be dynamic and changing with the demands of time. The problems of one generation need not be that of another. To tackle new or mutating challenges, there is a need for the Trusts to renew themselves every ‘three-to-five years’ to assess if there is anything that the government has not been able to do adequately; as Ratan says, today it may be ‘diseases and cures; [and] tomorrow it could be climate change’.

As a visionary who has earned the reputation of possessing an uncanny ability to foresee future problems, Ratan has emphasized the importance of climate change. The Tata Institute of Social Sciences has reflected his thinking, entering into ‘a strategic alliance with the University of Sydney’ in 2019, enabling it to raise a ‘funding of almost Rs 50 lakh annually’ which ‘will be used as seed funding for various research initiatives on climate change and its impact’ including those on diseases and livelihoods. This research initiative will ensure an informed and well-strategized response to the challenges of tomorrow.